

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S

FILM FORUM

THE ELEMENTS OF FILM · PART THREE · PEOPLE

CHAPTER 9 · GENRE

Genre is the promise a film makes before it starts. The shape comes after.

SUNSET BLVD.

From Dusk Till Dawn · 1996 · 108 min · dir. Robert Rodriguez ·
screenplay by Quentin Tarantino · Dimension Films

This is the print edition, with everything the online guide has. Some information will include spoilers, advised to stop at the end of "Before you press play" and resume after the credits.

THE TWO ROADS

STRAIGHT ON, OR A LEFT AT THE VISTA

Hollywood Boulevard runs east until it hits Sunset, and there is a theatre standing on the corner where they meet. Every chapter the room decides at that corner. This is the last one.

*Two sets of outlaws running for the Mexican border. Both films make the same promise inside twenty minutes: this is a crime film, and somebody is going to pay for it. *Thelma & Louise* keeps that promise to the last frame.*

*From *Dusk Till Dawn* keeps it for about an hour, reaches Mexico, and then becomes a different film altogether, with no warning and no apology. One honours the contract. The other tears it up halfway through and never looks back. Harvey Keitel is in both.*

SUNSET BLVD.

FROM DUSK TILL DAWN

1996 · 108 min · dir. Robert Rodriguez · screenplay by Quentin Tarantino · Dimension Films

Two bank-robbing brothers take a preacher and his kids hostage and run for the Mexican border, where they plan to lie low until dawn at a roadside bar.

Why it is on the ballot. For its first hour it is a tight, nasty Tarantino crime film. Then it becomes something else entirely, with no warning and no apology. It is the cleanest example of a film deliberately breaking the promise its genre made, and daring you to keep watching.

BEFORE YOU PRESS PLAY

Optional trivia.

IT WAS TARANTINO'S FIRST PAID WRITING JOB

Robert Kurtzman's makeup-effects company KNB paid him \$1,500 in 1990 to write the script, years before *Reservoir Dogs*. It was commissioned by an effects house rather than a studio, which tells you something about what they were paying for.

IT WAS GEORGE CLOONEY'S JUMP TO FILM

His first major film lead, shot while he was still starring as Doug Ross on *ER*. Tarantino plays his brother, Richie.

HARVEY KEITEL IS IN BOTH FILMS THIS CHAPTER

In *Thelma & Louise* he is the detective. Here he is Jacob Fuller, a pastor who has lost his faith, driving his kids across the border in an RV. Cheech Marin plays three roles: the border guard, Chet Pussy the barker, and Carlos.

WHILE YOU WATCH

Open each one only when you reach it.

THE FIRST SCENE

The promise

A liquor store, a sheriff, two brothers. Pure crime film, and very good at it.

Why it matters: The film makes its genre promise as loudly as it can. Remember how sure you felt about what kind of movie this was.

THE BORDER

The RV

The brothers and their hostages try to get through the checkpoint.

Why it matters: This is the last stretch where the crime story is the whole story. Watch it knowing that.

THE BAR

Clock the minute

Check the time when the film changes. It lands somewhere around 55 to 60 minutes in.

Why it matters: The switch arrives almost exactly where a classic structure would put the midpoint. The film breaks its genre and keeps its structure in the same move. Roger Ebert's summary: "For about an hour, we've been following the story of two mad-dog killers and their victims, and then suddenly a stripper in a Mexican bar turns into a vampire, and off we go."

THE LAST SHOT

Pull back

As the survivors drive away, the camera pulls back behind the bar.

Why it matters: The bar is sitting on the exposed top of a buried Mesoamerican step temple, its base ringed by decades of wrecked trucks. One reveal re-labels the whole second half: the trap is centuries old.

AFTER THE CREDITS

Everything here gives the film away. Keep it for afterwards.

[OPEN](#)

The snake was not in the script

Salma Hayek is genuinely afraid of snakes and refused the dance until she was told they would simply cast someone else — “frankly, I really needed to pay the rent.” She got through it by treating the snake as a symbol of her own power.

[OPEN](#)

The money

Made for about \$19 million, it took roughly \$26 million in the United States and about \$59 million worldwide, then became a franchise: two direct-to-video follow-ups and a television series from 2014 to 2016. The genre switch became the brand.

[OPEN](#)

The cast is a horror hall of fame

Tom Savini, the makeup-effects legend, plays Sex Machine. Fred Williamson, the blaxploitation star, plays Frost. Juliette Lewis plays Kate Fuller. The film is a crime picture staffed by horror people, which is the joke it is about to tell you.

01 When the film changed, did you feel tricked, or rewarded?

02 Think back through the first hour. Were there any clues?

03 Genre is a promise. Which film kept faith with you: the one that stayed a crime film, or the one that broke it?

Where to watch

Find it here → **[From Dusk Till Dawn on JustWatch](#)**, which shows every service carrying it right now, including free ones.

And two nobody uses: **Kanopy** and **Hoopla** are free with a library card. If you find it cheaper or free somewhere else, post the link in [my Substack](#).

Sources: Box Office Mojo · Roger Ebert · Fox News

THE LESSON

NOBODY CALLED IT NOIR

A FRENCH CRITIC NAMED SOMETHING HE SAW

After the Second World War, American films that had been kept out of occupied France arrived in Paris all at once: *The Maltese Falcon*, *Double Indemnity*, *Laura*, *Murder, My Sweet*. On 28 August 1946, in *L'Écran français*, the Italian-born critic Nino Frank wrote them up under the heading of a new kind of crime picture and called the mood *film noir*. The people who made those films in Hollywood had never heard the phrase. To them they were crime pictures.

AMERICANS MADE IT A GENRE

In the spring of 1972 the screenwriter Paul Schrader published "Notes on Film Noir" in *Film Comment*, and a generation of American directors started making noir deliberately: *Chinatown* (1974), *Body Heat* (1981), *Blade Runner* (1982). A label invented after the fact to describe a mood became a style you could aim at, with a checklist: hard shadows, voiceover, flashbacks, a doomed hero, a dangerous woman.

THAT IS HOW GENRE WORKS

Most genres are born this way. The films come first, the name comes later, and then the name becomes a promise to the audience. Once you know the name, you know what you have been promised: a western ends in a showdown, a romantic comedy ends together, a crime film makes somebody pay.

THREE THINGS A FILM CAN DO WITH THE PROMISE

ONE

KEEP IT

Deliver what the genre promised, as well as it can be delivered.

Die Hard · Heat · Thelma & Louise

TWO

BEND IT

Stay inside the genre while playing with what you expect.

Scream · Knives Out · Get Out

THREE

BREAK IT

Switch genres partway through and dare you to follow.

Psycho · Audition · From Dusk Till Dawn

A genre is really a preset of everything in this book: a structure, a clock, a point of view, a frame, a cut, a sound, a kind of character and a kind of performance, all agreed before the lights go down.

ONE PIECE OF VOCABULARY

A **genre switch** is a deliberate change of genre inside one film. It works when the first promise has been kept so well that the break feels like a betrayal, and then gives you something worth being betrayed for.

WHY THESE FILMS, AND WHY LAST

Chapter 1 was the shape of a story. This chapter is the promise made before the shape begins. So the season ends where it started, with the rules: two films, one that keeps them to the end and one that breaks them halfway through, and arrives anyway. Next time you are in a theatre, ask which one the film is doing.

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R. Julian Tuttle

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Questions, arguments, films you want on the ballot: heyilliteratewriter@gmail.com

Facts in this guide are drawn from the AFI Catalog, the Academy's awards database, Time, Slate, Roger Ebert, Box Office Mojo and Film Comment. Where sources disagree, the disagreement is printed rather than resolved.

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